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Twenty years ago, no one would have fathomed access to any service or product at a click or tap, while sitting at home. We transitioned so smoothly to this over the last 20 years, that one has to wonder what do the next 20 years have in store for us?

As I try to form a coherent vision of tomorrow by looking at the trends of today, the first thing that crosses my mind is the innovation in smartphones.

Pushing boundaries of expected norms

With smartphones already revolutionizing the way we engage with the world, it wouldn't be surprising if mobile technology continued to be the 'big disruptor' of the next decade. We've seen them move from simple phones to sophisticated multi-purpose devices. With the advancements that this industry alone has seen in the last 20 years, the next 20 might seem like science fiction. I believe that the biggest breakthrough will be introduced in the display design, with companies looking at bringing rollable, foldable and flexible displays, with OLED taking centre stage. This would allow smartphones to fit in the pockets of users as they travel, yet increase the display size when consuming content.

Wireless will dominate and evolve with demand to 6G or 7G, with a pinch of wired networks co-existing.

For the longest time, companies have been designing smartphones in

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The road to 2041

three primary colours – black, blue and white. It is only in the last 2 or 3 years that brands have started experimenting with funkier colours. As we move into the future, smartphones might become completely transparent, or allow users to change the colour on command.

Currently, batteries don't last for more than 2 days on an average and devices are regularly running out of juice and needing to be plugged in for hours at a time. Entering a true wireless charging era, you will be able to charge devices over-the-air, from a nearby transmitter or an isolated charging pile.

No place like [connected] home

Smart technologies (whether smartphones, smart watches, or smart TVs), learn and reduce the amount of inputs required by humans. Smart homes operate on the same principle: technology recognizes the homeowner's consumption patterns, decreases effort, and improves the house's security and safety.

Due to the civil work needed to automate a house, smart home technology was difficult to comprehend a few years ago. Smart devices used a common hub to transmit information to home gadgets such as lights, fans, switches, and other home devices, in addition to the wiring that a person had to get done at home. This slowed the introduction of smart homes and smart goods. Recently, in addition to smart lighting, switches, and thermostats, the smart home has seen multiple technological and availability advancements.

The ongoing trend of AI in our humble abodes has already started bringing together the vision of a connected home. Tech companies, including Mi India, are developing solutions and delivering standalone products such as smart TVs, robot cleaners, smart lights, etc, but the industry has a long way to go before truly connected and smart homes are

a reality. In the coming years, we can expect fully-developed algorithms that will be able to make you a cup of coffee while opening the blinds and customizing the bathroom temperature when it senses you waking up in the room.

A planet of the bots

Travelling to work using jetpacks or flying cars aren't possible yet, but autonomous vehicles (self-driving cars) are expected to mark their territory and find critical mass soon.

AI is a futuristic version of the Swiss army knife. It has the potential to increase productivity in any sector because it can relate narrowly to a growing number of domains – proving particularly useful in manufacturing.

Companies will begin to take steps into AI, robotics, and automation, with premature man-machine integration. As these tools become more sophisticated, intelligent, and seamless, they will transform business functions, improving efficiency and eradicating human error.

The next wave of 'green tech'

The need for Green technology will grow rapidly, with consumers looking for solutions that are environmentally friendly. More companies will start using technology in a manner that is not harmful to the environment or depletes natural resources. Funding for various transition technologies, such as smart grids and green hydrogen batteries, will increase in the future, resulting in accelerated implementation of these technologies.

We are living in a time of deep structural change where the boundaries between industries will continue to erode and present us with accelerating creativity and innovation. The future belongs to those who have the foresight to see the change and the courage and drive to make it happen.

All I can say is that it is a great time to be alive and witness the constant march of change, one day at a time. 